EVOLUTION, 1990–99

The Indian Army's expansion and modernization slowed in the 1990s, with the focus being on counter-insurgency tasks. Two corps were established after 1984. III Corps, established on 4 February 1985 and with 8 and 57 Mountain divisions under its command, covered Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura and Meghalaya. After India's intervention in Sri Lanka, the provisional HQ IPKF was retained as HQ XXI Corps, intended to be a third strike corps.

As the Kashmir Valley insurgency intensified, the Indian Army responded in 1990 by raising the Rashtriya Rifles, a dedicated counter-insurgency force. A total of 64 battalions were raised, their personnel provided by the Indian Army on deputation, with each battalion being affiliated to an infantry regiment. With prolonged counter-insurgency operations in the Kashmir Valley, a need was also identified for additional Special Forces (SF). This was met by converting the regular parachute battalions into SF battalions and raising a few additional SF units.

Only one more armoured regiment (52) was raised during the 1990s; regiments numbered 15, 19 and 76 had been raised in March 1985, with 50 and 51 established in July 1989. In December 1993, 33 Mechanised Division became an armoured division. A major development was the introduction of women into the Indian Army in other than medical services, starting in 1993.

The Indian Army adopted its new assault rifle, the locally produced 5.56mm Indian Small Arms System (INSAS), in 1990. Available in select-fire and LMG variants, the INSAS was intended to replace both the 7.62mm 1A1 battle rifle, which the Army had used since 1961, and the 7.62mm 1A LMG. Trials were completed by 1989, but the INSAS appeared in large numbers only in 1998–99, partly due to an initial shortage of 5.45mm ammunition. Originally envisaged in the early 1980s, the much-delayed 120mm-armed Arjun main battle tank continued to experience technical issues and cost escalations, only entering mass production after 1999. There was a critical shortfall in artillery, with the 155mm FH-77B towed howitzer being the last to enter service in 1986. The neglect of